

Psalms 117

Praise the Lord, All Ye Nations

O praise the Lord, all ye nations: praise him, all ye people

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

1 O praise the LORD, all ye nations: praise him, all ye people.

2 For his merciful kindness is great toward us: and the truth of the LORD endureth for ever. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

The shortest chapter in the entire Bible, Psalm 117 compresses the whole logic of universal praise into two lines: a summons addressed to every nation, and a reason—God's merciful kindness and enduring truth—stated with nothing wasted. Henry treats its brevity as its own kind of argument: some truths need no elaboration, only proclamation, and this psalm's inclusion of 'all nations' anticipates the gospel's later reach to the whole world, a connection Paul makes explicitly in Romans 15:11.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1

The call to praise is addressed with deliberate breadth from its very first word: all nations, all people—not Israel exclusively, but every people everywhere, summoned to praise the same Lord.

Verse 2

The reason is given as briefly as the summons: His merciful kindness is great toward us, and His truth endures forever. Two attributes—mercy and enduring truth—are offered as sufficient grounds for the praise of the entire world, closing with the familiar refrain: praise the Lord.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Some truths about God require no lengthy argument, only clear proclamation, and this psalm's brevity is itself part of its message: the reach of God's mercy and truth to 'all nations' needs nothing more elaborate than a direct, universal summons. Its inclusion of every people anticipates a scope the gospel would later make explicit, that praise belongs to the whole world, not to one nation's private possession.

Application for life today.

Let this psalm's brevity challenge any instinct to over-complicate your own praise—sometimes the most honest response to God's mercy and truth is simply to state it plainly and move on to actually doing it. Consider the psalm's global address and ask who beyond your own immediate circle needs to hear this same simple summons from you. Take just these two verses and use them literally as a short prayer of praise today, noticing how little is required to begin.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would it look like to let your own praise be as direct and unelaborate as this two-verse psalm, rather than always feeling it needs more explanation?

2. Who beyond your immediate circle or culture does this psalm's summons to 'all nations' (v. 1) call you to actually invite into praising God?

3. How does resting your praise on just two grounds—mercy and enduring truth (v. 2)—simplify a moment when gratitude feels complicated or hard to access?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).